

The Nine-Stage Developmental Rubric

*How the stage-graded intelligence lines are read — Humor, Parenting, Seduction,
Community-Founding, and the Finance stance*

How this rubric works

Five of the lines are **not** scored with a number. They are read as a developmental *altitude* on the nine-stage Spiral Dynamics ladder. Two things get read at once:

Intensity → **strength**. How strongly the capacity is present and identified-with says how *much* of it a person has.

Organization → **stage**. What the capacity is *organized around* — its motive, and how differentiated the self is from it — says what *altitude* it operates at. A higher stage does not mean more raw skill; it means a freer, more integrated relationship to the capacity. Someone can be ferociously skilled at a low altitude (fused, compulsive) or hold a modest skill at a high one (conscious, chosen, set-down-able).

Guardrails (all five lines): stage bands only, never a percentile; descriptive, never a verdict on character; and **not fed into the rarity composite** — the one exception being Financial Self-Management, which carries a separate artifact-based number in addition to this stance read.

The ladder (the nine altitudes)

1. **Beige — Survival**. Instinctive; immediate physical survival. (Rarely expresses in these domains for a functioning adult.)
2. **Purple — Tribal / Magical**. Kin, ritual, safety in the group, magical thinking.
3. **Red — Power / Impulsive**. Egocentric power and dominance; immediate gratification; the strong prevail.
4. **Blue — Order / Conformist**. Rules, duty, authority, right and wrong; belonging through obedience to a code.
5. **Orange — Achievement / Strategic**. Success, autonomy, rational self-interest, optimization, winning.
6. **Green — Communitarian / Relativistic**. Equality, community, feeling, pluralism, connection for its own sake.
7. **Yellow — Integrative / Systemic**. Second tier; flexible, systemic, holds paradox, functional over ideological.

8. **Turquoise — Holistic.** Global, whole-system, collective individualism.

9. **Coral — Emerging.** Speculative post-Turquoise; frontier, rarely assigned.

For adult capacities, the meaningful range is **Red (3) through Yellow/Turquoise (7–8)**. Stages 1–2 and 9 are noted for completeness but are seldom where these lines actually express.

Humor

- **Red (3).** Dominance and deflection — mockery, cutting others down, controlling the room by force of personality.

- **Blue (4).** In-group and conventional — bonding through shared norms; jokes that police the group.

- **Orange (5).** Performance wit — humor as craft and status; the deliberately funny person who works the material.

- **Green (6).** Subversive and relativistic — humor that punctures pretension, holds paradox, sees every side.

- **Yellow / Turquoise (7–8).** Liberating humor — lightness that frees rather than wounds, holds the tragic and comic at once, used to open rather than dominate.

Parenting

- **Red (3).** Child as extension or property; obedience secured by power; the child's own mind not really in view.

- **Blue (4).** Duty and obedience; strong structure, warmth conditional on compliance; "because I said so."

- **Orange (5).** Optimization — the high-achieving parent engineering a high-achieving child; warmth present but outcome-driven.

- **Green (6).** Child-centered, feelings-forward, autonomy-honoring — with the permissive risk of under-structuring.

- **Yellow / Turquoise (7–8).** Holds it all at once — warmth *and* firm structure *and* genuine autonomy, tracking the child's own developmental unfolding rather than imposing a template.

(Grounded in Parental Reflective Functioning — Slade; Fonagy et al.; PRFQ — and authoritative-parenting research — Baumrind; Steinberg. Formative, never a "good/bad parent" score.)

Seduction

- **Red (3).** Survival — the only card, deployed compulsively; "the rules don't reach me." Fused, undifferentiated, scarcity-driven.
- **Blue (4).** Channeled into sanctioned roles — the devoted, charming spouse; magnetism bounded by convention and duty.
- **Orange (5).** Strategic and knowing — deployed deliberately to advance, to climb, for profit motive. A tool consciously wielded rather than a compulsion.
- **Green (6).** Toward mutuality and connection — less instrumental, more about resonance; or, in its shadow, a diffuse "charming everyone" without a fixed aim.
- **Yellow / Turquoise (7–8).** Held with distance — one capacity among many, not the self. Used consciously and ethically, or set down at will.

(Read from stance and strategy only — never from appearance, wealth, or outcome-inference. See the seduction module for the full guardrails.)

Community-Founding / Social Architecture

- **Red (3).** Gathering a following around one's own power — a crew, a scene centered on the founder; collapses without them.
- **Blue (4).** Building around shared identity, tradition, or institution — clubs, congregations, orders; durable but rule-bound.
- **Orange (5).** Strategic network-building — assembling circles for mutual advancement and reach; effective, instrumentally aimed.
- **Green (6).** Genuine *communitas* — weaving belonging for its own sake; egalitarian circles that hold because members are truly bonded.
- **Yellow / Turquoise (7–8).** Building structures designed to outlast the builder — seeding communities with their own governance and life, so persistence past the founder is intentional, not accidental.

(Carries a demonstrated floor from the observable output: how many, how long, and whether they run without the founder — the durability test is the crux.)

Financial Self-Management (the stance)

- **Red (3).** Money as immediate power and gratification — spend it now, get-rich impulses, no horizon.
- **Blue (4).** Money as duty and security — save because it's right, thrift as virtue, debt as shame; disciplined but rigid.

- **Orange (5).** Money as achievement and leverage — optimizing, investing, building wealth as scorekeeping and freedom-through-success.

- **Green (6).** Money as means to values — enough-ness, ethical spending, wealth in service of people and meaning.

- **Yellow / Turquoise (7–8).** Stewardship — fluid, non-anxious mastery; money as one instrument among many, held without grasping, deployed with long and wide horizons.

*(This line is the exception: it carries a real numeric measure from verifiable artifacts — savings rate, net-worth-to-income — **in addition** to this stance read. Market-beating claims are excluded from the score.)*

Applying it

For each line, name the altitude and give a one-sentence read — e.g., "Humor at an achievement altitude (Orange): worked deliberately for status and craft," or "Parenting at Yellow: warmth and structure and autonomy held together." Intensity tells you how much; organization tells you how high. Never a number (Finance's separate artifact measure excepted), never fed into rarity, always described rather than judged.